charge of combat readiness. Psychological warfare was not part of the American strategy, but the American commanders hoped that the Soviets would become so used to American planes in the air that when the time came for an air strike they would be caught off guard, unable to distinguish bombers from reconnaissance aircraft.[3]

On the evening of October 26 Garbuz was summoned to General Pliev's office after Pliev had spent a good half of the day in the company of Fidel Castro and other Cuban and Soviet commanders. Also in attendance was Pliev's deputy in charge of air defenses, General Stepan Grechko, and the chief of staff of the Group of Soviet Forces in Cuba, General Pavel Akindinov. The discussion, remembered Garbuz, focused on "what they [the Americans] had uncovered and what they hadn't … because tomorrow they could be fired upon and we'd have to decide what to remove and what to replace." The generals concluded that many of the ballistic missile sites under the command of General Igor Statsenko had been discovered by the Americans. "And we reported to Moscow—I wrote it in my own hand rather quickly—that our opponent had managed to uncover some strategic areas," recalled Garbuz.[4]

Pliev sent a telegram drafted by Garbuz to Moscow reporting that "[a] decision has been made to use all available antiaircraft resources in case of a strike against our sites by American aviation." Khrushchev and Malinovsky would approve the decision later that day, but it had gone into effect immediately. "We received a secret coded telegram: be prepared for military action; an American intervention is expected," recalled Captain Nikolai Antonets, chief of staff of the missile battalion of the 507th regiment, 27th Air Defense Division, in the vicinity of Banes in eastern Cuba. "We were allowed to go on air and turn on radio communications. Everyone felt that war was possible." Major Nikolai Serovoi, who was on duty that night at the headquarters of the 27th Division, remembered an even more specific instruction concerning the time of the invasion. "A coded telegram has been received: war at dawn tomorrow. Make the elements of the division combat-ready, but secretly," Serovoi was informed in a phone call from the division commander, Colonel Georgii Voronkov.[5]

The new order from Pliev was in line with instructions earlier received from Moscow. In the tense evening hours of October 22, when the agitated